

In 2023, *Sportstar* reported how Ngamgouhou Mate, the captain of the Indian U-17 team that had won the South Asian Football Championships, and two of his Kuki teammates, Levis Zangminlun and Vumlental Hangshing, had to embark on a gruelling 15-hour, 438-km journey through Dimapur in Nagaland to reach their families — some in refugee camps — rather than take the shorter route through Imphal.

'I don't know how long I can do this'

A couple of days ago, 22-year-old Joel Haokip made a similar journey as he returned to his family after a stint in professional football with Dempo Football Club last year.



Uncertain future: Joel Haokip (front row, second from right) last represented Manipur at the 2022 National Games in Gujarat. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Joel was part of the Manipur side that competed at the 2022 National Games in Gujarat. Although the team exited in the group stage after blowing a 2-0 lead against Kerala, Joel, who played as an attacking midfielder, had a good tournament — scoring two goals and providing one

assist for his team.

That competition was also the last time Joel represented Manipur.

Joel was born and raised in Imphal, where he trained at the prestigious Classic Football Academy — run by former India international Renedy Singh. He had represented Manipur from the U-14 age group as a part of the team that won the Khelo India competition. He was also one of Classic Football Academy's top prospects and, on the morning of May 3, 2023, had played a match against NorthEast United's U-21 side. "Funnily enough, that match was actually one of the best games I've played. After the match, we started hearing bad news coming out of Churachandpur. We thought it would be nothing and planned to go out to the city, but that was when my parents called me back. That whole night was chaos. The rioters were yelling that they would kill us, and as men, we had to go out with sticks to try and protect the neighbourhood," he says.

It was only with the arrival of the CRPF that Joel's family was able to make its way to a refugee camp and eventually out of the capital to Kangpokpi. "I just took my boots with me. All my trophies, medals, and anything from my life as a footballer in Imphal got left behind," he says. Almost before his family found a place to stay, Joel says he crossed the state border and made his way to Kolkata. "I love football so much. I was desperate to be able to play again," he says.

Although Classic Football Academy publicly announced that they had ended their partnership with him, Joel says he was supported by Renedy in finding a club and a place to stay in Kolkata.

The resumption of his career hasn't been smooth. "When I was in Classic Football Academy, we had chefs, nutritionists, and strength and conditioning experts. I only had to concentrate on my football. The biggest challenge I faced after leaving Manipur has been taking care of myself. I fell sick very often," he says.

Now in his second year of playing football outside his state, Joel carries a lot of resentment. Once considered one of his academy's top talents, he is struggling to live up to the potential he once saw in himself. "I think my career would have been very different if the conflict had not happened. I was just starting to make a name for myself. I was just about to break out. In Kolkata, I started from zero. Wherever you go in India, you have to be three to four times better than the locals to get a chance to play," he says.

Joel persists because he loves the sport too much but admits it is becoming difficult. "Many of my (Kuki) teammates have already stopped playing. Some are studying, and others have started working. I really thought I was going to play professionally, but now I really don't know how long I'm going to do this. I'm going to keep trying, though," he says.